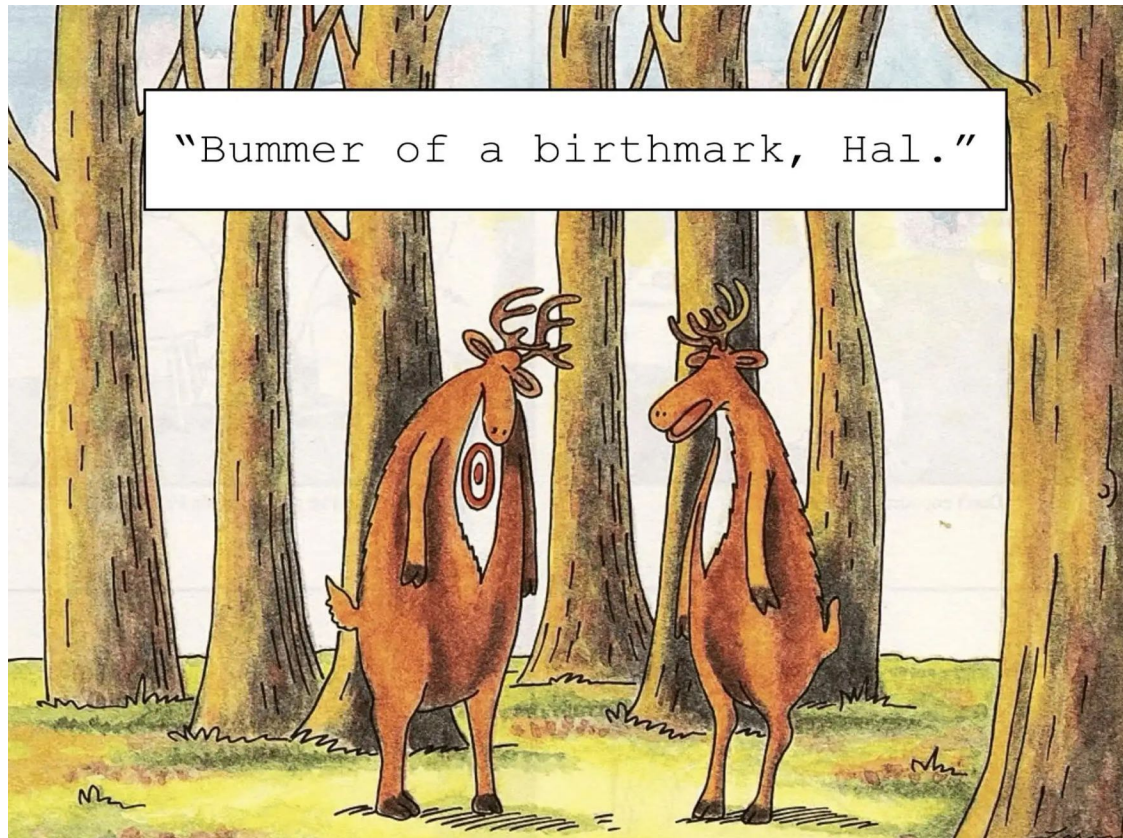


Armstrong

— Financial Services —



Is My IFA Life Insurance Plan a Tax Shelter?

*Application of subsection 237.1(1), section 143.2, and Regulation 3100 to IFA structures
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This memorandum provides a comprehensive framework for analyzing whether an Immediate Financing Arrangement (IFA) qualifies as a tax shelter under the Income Tax Act (ITA). It systematically examines the statutory definition of a tax shelter, the identification of the relevant property, the connection between the loan and that property, and the classification of the financing as a limited-recourse amount. Furthermore, it outlines the resulting prescribed-benefit calculation, details the consequences of operating an unregistered tax shelter, and addresses common objections from lenders and promoters. Ultimately, the objective of this document is not to pass judgment on any specific IFA, but rather to equip readers with the objective statutory questions required to make that determination themselves.

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Background: The IFA Structure and Why Deductibility Matters

In a standard IFA structure, a client purchases a permanent life insurance policy and pays the premium out of pocket. Immediately afterward, a bank lends the client an amount equal to that premium, secured in part by the policy's cash value. The loan proceeds are then invested. Because the loan matches the premium dollar-for-dollar, the net cash outlay in the year of the transaction is \$0. The debt is generally intended to remain outstanding for life and to be repaid from the tax-free proceeds of the policy on death, so the illustration typically shows the projected loan subtracted from the death benefit to arrive at a "net death benefit" figure.

While an IFA renders the client cash-neutral in the year of the transaction – the loan proceeds equal, dollar-for-dollar, the premium just paid – it does not make the life insurance free. Instead, it replaces a known, finite premium obligation with a lifelong debt that must be serviced annually.

The cost of carrying that debt is the annual interest charge, which is maintained for the life of the insured. The arrangement's economics depend heavily on whether this interest charge can be rendered tax-deductible under the Income Tax Act. If the loan were used directly to pay for the insurance premium, that deduction would not be a possibility, as paragraph 20(1)(c) explicitly excludes interest on money borrowed to acquire a life insurance policy.

Without a tax deduction, this lifelong interest burden is highly problematic. If the interest is capitalized and re-collateralized annually, the compounding debt could eventually outrun the policy's cash value, leaving the client with little or no insurance net of the debt. Alternatively, if the interest is paid out-of-pocket annually, the client is exposed to interest rate variability; over a lifetime, this cumulative after-tax cost could easily exceed what it would have cost to purchase the target net death benefit outright using standard, unfinanced insurance products.

To render the interest deductible and thus the plan financially viable, the IFA's novel representation relies on specific sequencing and the deliberate, represented use of funds. By paying the premium out of pocket first, and then representing that the borrowed funds are used strictly to acquire an income-producing investment (and are not related to the payment of the insurance premium), the resulting tax deductions are represented as achieved, and the illustrated tax savings are integrated directly into the arrangement's stated financial quantum. This sequencing dictates the financial outcome of the overall plan—and the illustration presents the policy, the loan, the investment, and the tax-deductible interest together as a single, cohesive strategy. Yet, that very design choice—matching a loan exactly to a premium amount but not the premium itself, and representing that the full amount of the loan was invested to produce a deduction—is precisely what brings the arrangement within the ITA's tax-shelter definition, as set out below.

The Statutory Definition of a Tax Shelter

Subsection 237.1(1) of the Income Tax Act defines a tax shelter, in relevant part, as an investment in property where it is reasonable to consider, having regard to statements or representations made or proposed to be made in connection with the property, that a purchaser could reasonably be expected to have deductions, losses, or credits within the first four years equal to or exceeding the purchaser's net cost of the property. Net cost is determined after subtracting any "prescribed benefits" expected to be received in respect of the property, directly or indirectly.

The CRA's own public guidance ("What is a tax shelter?") summarizes the test as follows:

"...a tax shelter is:... an investment in property... where it is reasonable to consider, based on statements or representations made or proposed to be made in connection with... the property, that within the first four years of buying an investment in the property... the buyer... will have losses, deductions, or credits equal to or greater than the net cost of the original investment or of the property acquired... 'Net cost' is net of any prescribed benefits expected to be received or enjoyed, directly or indirectly, by the person..."

This produces three variables that must be established before the test can be applied:

Variable	Question	Statutory Basis
A	What is the cost of the property acquired?	ITA s. 237.1(1)(b)(ii)(A) – cost determined without reference to s. 143.2
B	What prescribed benefit – including any limited-recourse financing – is expected in respect of that property?	ITA s. 237.1(1)(b)(ii)(B); ITR Reg. 3100; ITA ss. 143.2(7) and 143.2(12)
C	What deductions, losses, or credits are represented in the first four years?	ITA s. 237.1(1)(b)(i)

The statutory test under subsection 237.1(1) resolves to a simple equation:

If $C \geq (A - B)$, the arrangement crosses the tax-shelter threshold and registration is required.

Counterintuitively, this test is triggered by representations made or proposed to be made – through sales meetings, promotional materials, or financial illustrations – rather than by the arrangement's actual commercial outcome. The phrase "proposed to be made" is significant: the tax-shelter analysis can be engaged before the representations are actually made to a purchaser, based on what is intended to be represented. Subsection 237.1(4) requires a Tax Shelter ID Number before the arrangement may be sold or issued, regardless of whether the represented deductions are ultimately sustained on audit.

In an IFA, where the loan matches the premium dollar-for-dollar to create a cash-neutral arrangement while simultaneously representing full interest deductibility, the design directly sets up a potential \$0 net cost. In that context, this statutory calculation is not peripheral; overlooking it exposes the arrangement and its participants to severe penalties, regardless of intent.

The sections that follow walk through this three-part statutory cascade as applied to a standard IFA: first 1) identifying the **relevant property (A)**, then 2) establishing whether the loan constitutes a **prescribed benefit in respect of that property (B)**, and finally 3) applying the arithmetic to the **represented deductions (C)**.

1. Identifying the Relevant Property (A)

The relevant property analyzed here is not the life insurance policy. Instead, Variable A is the independently identifiable *investment property* acquired with the borrowed funds—the very *investment* assumed in the illustration to qualify for a paragraph 20(1)(c) interest deduction.

This follows directly from the structure of paragraph 20(1)(c). Under the Act, interest is deductible only where it is paid on “*borrowed money used for the purpose of earning income from a business or property*,” while interest on money borrowed “*to acquire a life insurance policy*” is expressly excluded. Consequently, if an IFA illustration represents any interest as deductible, that representation is possible only on the basis that the borrowed funds are used to acquire a qualifying, income-producing investment. The illustration’s own “deductible interest” line is, in effect, a representation that a qualifying investment property exists to which the loan was applied.

Where the illustration represents the *entire* interest charge on the loan as deductible on the basis that the *entire* loan was used to acquire the investment, that representation identifies the full amount of the loan as financing for that investment. This conclusion is corroborated by CRA’s Tax Shelter Form T5001, which requires disclosure of the “represented deductions” and pre-populates “interest expense” as a deduction category, reflecting the same analytical structure used here.

2. Establishing the Prescribed Benefit (B)

Once the relevant investment property has been identified (Variable A), the next step in the statutory formula is determining whether a “prescribed benefit” (Variable B) exists in relation to that property. Under Regulation 3100(3), treating the bank loan as a prescribed benefit requires establishing two distinct criteria:

1. **In Respect Of:** The financing must be connected to, or made “in respect of”, the property.
2. **The Limited-Recourse Amount:** The loan itself must legally qualify as a limited-recourse amount under section 143.2 of the Income Tax Act.

Only when both of these criteria are satisfied does the financing become a prescribed benefit that reduces the net cost of the property in the statutory calculation.

2.1 The “In Respect Of” Connection

It must be shown that the loan is “in respect of” the property, since Regulation 3100 defines a prescribed benefit by reference to amounts reasonably expected in respect of an interest in property. The phrase “in respect of” has been given the widest possible scope by the Supreme Court of Canada in *Nowegijick v. The Queen*, [1983] 1 S.C.R. 29:

“The words ‘in respect of’ are, in my opinion, words of the widest possible scope. They import such meanings as ‘in relation to’, ‘with reference to’ or ‘in connection with’. The phrase ‘in respect of’ is probably the widest of any expression intended to convey some connection between two related subject matters”

Here, the connection is direct rather than incidental: the loan is represented as the source of the deductible interest, deductible only because the loaned funds were used to acquire the investment. The promoter cannot obtain the paragraph 20(1)(c) deduction without representing that qualifying use of the borrowed funds – the same borrowing tested for limited-recourse status under section 143.2. The represented deduction is thus tied to the loan, and the loan to the investment, satisfying the *Nowegijick* standard. This tracing is a feature of paragraph 20(1)(c), not unique to an IFA – it is the loan's limited-recourse character under subsection 143.2(7), addressed in Section 2.2, that does the distinguishing work.

2.2 Is the Loan a Limited-Recourse Amount?

The second element is whether the loan is a “limited-recourse amount.” Industry practitioners often point to outside collateral, personal guarantees, and the lender's ability to demand repayment as evidence that the debt is “fully recourse.” These features are relevant to a bank's commercial credit assessment, but they do not answer the statutory question. Subsection 143.2(7) is a deeming provision that overrides ordinary commercial characterization:

“...the unpaid principal amount of the indebtedness shall be deemed to be a limited-recourse amount... unless bona fide arrangements were made in writing, at the time the indebtedness arose, for repayment of all principal and interest... within a reasonable period not exceeding 10 years.”

The central issue for a standard IFA is the principal-repayment condition: a bona fide written arrangement, made at inception, to repay all principal within 10 years. IFA loans are typically structured as interest-only, annually renewable demand loans intended to remain outstanding until death. While s. 143.2(7) also requires interest to be paid annually within 60 days of the tax year-end, satisfying that separate rule does not bypass the 10-year principal requirement.

Promoters are likely to argue that an annually renewable demand loan is by its own terms shorter than 10 years. Subsection 143.2(12) anticipates this argument: where a repayment arrangement can reasonably be considered part of a “series of loans or other indebtedness and repayments” extending more than 10 years, the debtor is treated as *not* having made arrangements to repay within 10 years.

2.3 Completing the Prescribed-Benefit Analysis

Once a loan is established to be both (2.1) in respect of the relevant property, and (2.2) a limited-recourse amount, Regulation 3100(3) applies with statutory automaticity. It provides that a **limited-recourse amount in respect of a property**, determined under subsection 143.2(1), (7), or (13), is a **prescribed benefit in respect of that property**.

With the property identified (A) and the loan established as a prescribed benefit in respect of that property (B), both inputs required for the tax-shelter calculation are in place.

3. Identifying the Represented Deductions (C)

The final element of the three-part quantum is determining whether deductions, losses, or credits have been represented in the first four years of the plan (Variable C). In the context of a standard IFA illustration, the presence of these represented deductions—specifically, the paragraph 20(1)(c) interest deduction—is an obvious point that requires no further complex analysis, as it is explicitly printed on the illustration itself.

However, as will be shown in the calculation shortly, the actual quantum of these represented deductions need only be greater than zero. In other words, there simply must be at least some representation of a deduction. As we will see, the specific dollar amount of that deduction becomes legally irrelevant in the mathematical context of a fully financed IFA.

The Tax-Shelter Calculation

With variables A, B, and C established, the final step in determining unregistered tax-shelter status is arithmetic rather than interpretation. The statutory test in subsection 237.1(1) requires registration if the represented deductions (C) equal or exceed the cost of the property (A) minus the prescribed benefits (B). The formula is:

$$\text{If } C \geq (A - B) \rightarrow \text{Tax Shelter}$$

Because the IFA illustration represents that the full amount of the investment was acquired with the borrowed funds — meaning the borrowed amount and the invested amount are the exact same figure — the cost of the property (A) and the prescribed benefit against it (B) are identical. Therefore:

$$(A - B) = \$0$$

This is not the product of any double-counting or aggressive interpretation. Section 237.1 determines the cost of the property without reference to section 143.2; the limited-recourse characterization enters the calculation separately, through the prescribed-benefit deduction under paragraph 237.1(1)(b)(ii)(B). The \$0 net cost figure results directly from the statute itself.

Once the net cost is \$0, the only remaining question is whether the represented deductions in the first four years (C) exceed \$0. Because $C > \$0$ is satisfied the moment C is any amount greater than zero, the size of the represented deduction is legally irrelevant to the outcome of the test: a represented deduction of even \$1 satisfies the threshold completely.

This is the precise mechanism by which a fully leveraged IFA, represented and structured in the manner described above, mechanically satisfies the statutory tax-shelter definition without requiring any additional facts or abusive intent.

A Note on Partial Financing

The analysis does not depend on financing 100% of the insurance premium. The relevant comparison is not between the premium and the loan; it is between the acquisition cost of the property represented as having been acquired with the borrowed funds and the limited-recourse amount treated as a prescribed benefit in respect of that property.

Thus, if \$70,000 is borrowed and the entire \$70,000 is represented as being used to acquire an investment having an acquisition cost of \$70,000, the relevant amounts are $A = \$70,000$ and $B = \$70,000$. Likewise, if \$50,000 is borrowed and used to acquire a \$50,000 investment, $A = B = \$50,000$. In either case, $A - B = \$0$.

The percentage of the insurance premium financed is not itself determinative. What matters is whether the borrowing and the acquisition cost of the represented property are coextensive.

Consequences of Unregistered Tax-Shelter Status

Where an arrangement meets the statutory definition of a tax shelter, the promoter is required, before selling, issuing, or accepting consideration in respect of the arrangement, to obtain a Tax Shelter Identification Number from the CRA and to file the required prescribed information, including a list of subscribers. Obtaining an identification number does not signify CRA approval of the arrangement or of any represented deduction; it is a disclosure mechanism, and registration typically results in increased audit scrutiny of the arrangement.

If an arrangement meeting the tax-shelter definition is sold without registration, or if the required filings are not made, the following consequences may apply:

- **Denial of deductions.** Under subsection 237.1(6), no amount may be deducted or claimed in respect of a tax shelter unless the prescribed form containing the tax-shelter identification number has been filed.
- **Reduction of cost basis.** Section 143.2 contains rules that can reduce the capital cost or other expenditure amount of a tax-shelter investment by the amount of any specified limited-recourse debt associated with it.

- **Promoter and third-party penalties.** Under subsection 237.1(7.4), selling or accepting consideration in respect of an unregistered tax shelter can result in a penalty equal to the greater of \$500 and 25% of the applicable statutory consideration amount. Separately, section 163.2 provides for third-party civil penalties where a person makes or participates in a false statement in connection with a taxpayer's affairs.

Conclusion

A mechanical tax-shelter analysis of an IFA does not require any speculative recharacterization of the arrangement or resort to the General Anti-Avoidance Rule (GAAR). Following the promoter's own representations and the taxpayer's own tracing of borrowed funds for paragraph 20(1)(c) purposes is sufficient to raise the statutory questions addressed above: what property was acquired, whether the loan financing that property is a limited-recourse amount, whether that amount is a prescribed benefit in respect of the property, and whether the represented deductions in the first four years equal or exceed the resulting net cost.

Where those facts converge – a loan matched dollar-for-dollar to the premium, represented as fully invested, generating a represented deduction, and lacking a bona fide 10-year repayment arrangement – the arrangement would satisfy the numerical test in subsection 237.1(1), and the registration requirements of subsection 237.1(4) would apply before the arrangement may lawfully be sold. Any professional reviewing a specific IFA arrangement should be able to identify the precise point in this statutory chain at which the facts of that particular arrangement diverge from this analysis. Where they do not diverge, the statutory consequences apply regardless of the intentions of the parties involved.

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A Diagnostic Test for Advisors

An advisor or promoter who disagrees with the application of this analysis to a particular arrangement does not need to accept or refute the analysis in the abstract. The following questions can be applied directly to the specific illustration and loan documentation at issue:

1. What property does the illustration represent as being acquired with the borrowed funds? If the answer is a qualifying income-producing investment intended to satisfy paragraph 20(1)(c), the relevant property has been identified.

2. Why is the interest on the loan represented as deductible? If the answer depends on the borrowed funds having been used to acquire that income-producing investment, the loan-to-property relationship has been expressly represented.
3. Was there a bona fide, written arrangement, made at the time the debt arose, requiring repayment of all principal and interest within 10 years? If yes, that arrangement should be identified and reviewed. If no, subsection 143.2(7) must be addressed.
4. **If the loan is a limited-recourse amount, on what basis is it not a prescribed benefit in respect of the investment identified in Question 1, given Regulation 3100(3)?**
5. If the loan is a prescribed benefit in respect of the investment, what is the resulting statutory net cost under the formula in Section 2?
6. If the represented deductions in the first four years are greater than \$0, and the net cost calculated in Question 5 is \$0, how does the arrangement avoid satisfying the numerical test in subsection 237.1(1)?

Anticipating the Objections

“This would make every investment loan a tax shelter.” It would not. An ordinary investment loan typically involves an independently selected investment, borrowing sized to the investor’s own financing needs, a bona fide repayment arrangement, no exact matching of the loan to an unrelated cost such as an insurance premium, and no representation that the arrangement produces a \$0 net cost. Those facts do not produce the same result. The argument advanced in this memorandum is narrower and fact-specific: it applies where the financing exactly matches the premium, the proceeds are represented as invested, the resulting interest is represented as fully deductible, and the principal is intended to remain outstanding beyond 10 years. That is a specific fact pattern, not a description of investment borrowing generally.

“The bank treats the loan as fully recourse.” This observation, while accurate as a description of the bank’s commercial position, does not answer the statutory question. A personal guarantee, additional collateral, a right of set-off, or the lender’s ability to demand repayment may all be relevant to a bank’s internal credit risk assessment, but none of them constitutes a bona fide written arrangement made at the time the debt arose to repay the principal within 10 years, as subsection 143.2(7) requires. Nor does a stated 10-year term settle the matter: under subsection 143.2(12), a facility retired only by drawing a new loan against the same policy is treated as part of a single series extending beyond 10 years, regardless of how the individual instrument is papered – and such a term is not, in substance, a bona fide arrangement to begin with if the parties never intend for the facility to actually terminate. The commercial and statutory characterizations of the same loan can diverge, and it is the statutory characterization that governs the tax-shelter test.

Scope and Limits of This Analysis

This analysis does not establish that every IFA is a tax shelter. It does not establish that every investment loan secured in whole or in part by a life insurance policy is a tax shelter. It does not establish that every deduction represented in an insurance illustration is valid or sustainable on audit. It does not eliminate the need to examine the actual loan agreement, the actual investment made, the tracing of borrowed funds, the specific representations made to the purchaser, and the specific repayment arrangements in place, in every individual case.

What the analysis does establish is narrower: a fully leveraged IFA, in which the borrowed funds are matched dollar-for-dollar to the premium and represented as fully invested, in which the resulting interest is represented as deductible, and in which the debt lacks a bona fide written arrangement to repay principal within 10 years, can produce a statutory net cost of \$0 under subsection 237.1(1). Where that is the case, any represented deduction greater than \$0 in the first four years satisfies the numerical threshold of the tax-shelter definition, triggering the registration requirement under subsection 237.1(4) irrespective of the parties' intentions. This is a statutory calculation, not an argument from intention, and not an invocation of the General Anti-Avoidance Rule.

Appendix A: The Statutory Chain

- **ITA s. 143.2(7):** Deems the unpaid principal of an indebtedness to be a limited-recourse amount unless there is a bona fide written arrangement, made at the time the debt arose, to repay principal and interest within a reasonable period not exceeding 10 years, together with compliant interest-payment terms.
- **ITA s. 143.2(12):** Extends the analysis to a series of loans or other indebtedness and repayments that, considered together, extends beyond 10 years from when the series begins.
- **ITR Regulation 3100(3):** Defines a prescribed benefit, for tax-shelter purposes, to include an amount that is a limited-recourse amount under s. 143.2(1), (7), or (13), subject to exclusions.
- **ITA s. 237.1(1):** Defines a tax shelter by comparing represented deductions, losses, or credits in the first four years against the its cost less any prescribed benefits.
- **ITA s. 237.1(4):** Requires a Tax Shelter Identification Number to be obtained before a tax shelter is sold, issued, or funded.
- **ITA s. 237.1(6):** Prohibits deductions or claims in respect of a tax shelter unless the prescribed form containing the tax-shelter identification number has been filed.
- **ITA s. 143.2(6):** Contains rules that can reduce the capital cost or expenditure amount of a tax-shelter investment by specified limited-recourse amounts.
- **ITA s. 237.1(7.4) and s. 163.2:** Provide for promoter penalties in respect of unregistered tax shelters and third-party civil penalties for false statements made under a culpable-conduct standard, respectively.

Appendix B: Case Law and CRA Ruling Resources

- **CRA Technical Interpretation 2006-0196251C6 and CRA Advance Income Tax Ruling 2009-0340381R3 (2010):** CRA positions discussing demand loans and limited-recourse characterization under s 143.2 in the context of a leveraged insurance/annuity arrangement.
- ***Nowegijick v. The Queen*, [1983] 1 S.C.R. 29:** Supreme Court of Canada authority establishing that the phrase "in respect of" is to be given the widest possible scope in tax legislation, requiring only a nexus or "thought connection" between two subject matters.
- ***Hexalog Ltée c. La Reine*, 2005 TCC 67:** Tax Court authority for the proposition that, where an asset, a financing facility, and a reinvestment strategy are marketed and implemented as a single integrated package, they may be treated as one composite property for purposes of subsection 237.1(1).
- ***Krumm v. Canada*, 2021 FCA 78:** Confirms that the tax-shelter test is an objective statutory inquiry, applied by reference to the representations made and the statutory cost calculation, rather than a subjective inquiry into intent.
- ***Canada v. Baxter*, 2007 FCA 172 and *Jevremovic v. Canada*, 2007 FCA 125:** Federal Court of Appeal decisions upholding the statutory reporting consequences that flow from unregistered tax shelters.
- **CRA Circular IC01-1R2, "Third-Party Civil Penalties":** CRA's administrative guidance on the application of section 163.2 to advisors who promote aggressive tax structures.
- **CALU Practice Note, "Best practices for insured leveraging programs – Part II" (May 30, 2023):** Industry guidance to insurance advisors on interest deductibility, the collateral insurance deduction, the tax-shelter rules, and the General Anti-Avoidance Rule as applied to early and immediate financing arrangements.

Appendix C: Characteristics of Typical IFA Bank Loans

Based on standard industry loan documentation, IFA bank facilities commonly exhibit the following features, each of which is relevant to the statutory analysis above:

- **Demand-loan structure with no fixed maturity.** The facility is typically an interest-only demand loan, with no contractual requirement to pay principal within a 10-year period.
- **Death as a triggering repayment event.** The death of the insured is generally treated as the point at which the outstanding balance is to be repaid, consistent with an intended term spanning the life of the insured rather than a fixed period.
- **Direct linkage to the reinvested funds.** Loan advances are frequently conditioned on evidence that the proceeds will be reinvested at a value at least equal to the loan amount, tying the financing directly to the investment rather than as two independent transactions.
- **Controlled tracing.** Loan terms commonly prohibit using the facility, or the policy's accumulated cash value, to pay the insurance premium directly – a restriction that has the

effect of enforcing the two-step "pay premium, then borrow and invest" sequence required to support a paragraph 20(1)(c) deduction.

- **Facility limits tied to premiums and cash value.** Annual advances and overall facility limits are frequently sized to cumulative premiums paid and the policy's cash surrender value, rather than structured as a general-purpose credit facility.
- **Product branding as an integrated strategy.** These facilities are frequently marketed and documented as a named, integrated product tied to the specific life insurance policy, reinforcing the characterization of the arrangement as a single package rather than two unrelated transactions.
- **Lender disclaimer regarding tax treatment.** Loan agreements typically include a disclaimer that the lender makes no representation regarding the tax consequences of the arrangement, which has the effect of isolating the insurance promoter as the party responsible for the paragraph 20(1)(c) representations that give rise to the statutory tax-shelter analysis.

Any review of a specific IFA arrangement should be conducted against the complete documentation for that arrangement: the actual loan agreement, policy illustration, financing conditions, and marketing materials, rather than by reference to these general characteristics.

Industry and Regulatory Context

This analysis is not an isolated legal theory; the statutory tension it highlights is now being formally acknowledged by major Canadian life insurance carriers. In its April 2026 published guidance on leveraged life insurance, Manulife explicitly warned advisors that the tax shelter rules are a live consideration when leveraging occurs within the first four years. Crucially, Manulife's guidance validates the exact statutory math and representation triggers detailed in this memorandum, stating:

"The tax shelter rules may be a consideration in the leveraged insurance context where there is a leveraging within the first 4 years of the arrangement ... It may be the case that any deductions for interest or collateral insurance may exceed that "cost", and therefore may trigger the tax shelter rules. There is also a requirement for the promoter to make statements or representations about the tax benefits of the arrangement. This requirement may be met if interest or collateral insurance deductions are discussed or illustrated in connection with a tax shelter property." (Source: Manulife Tax Retirement & Estate Planning Services, "Leveraged life insurance under personal ownership," April 2026).

If statutory warnings and carrier guidance are not enough, consider the CRA's explicit response to Question 1 at the 2026 CRA Roundtable (Reference: 2026-1089291C6) regarding their current audit activities:

"We continue to seek out, audit and re-assess all arrangements which attempt to utilize insurance products or insurance-like products to gain a tax advantage not envisioned by tax policy and legislation. Within CRA, the High Net Worth Compliance Directorate (HNWCD) develops, implements, and coordinates business intelligence and compliance initiatives to address non-compliance in the High Net Worth population through the Audit Program Division, which includes the Aggressive Tax Planning audit program (ATP), and the Tax Promoter and Advisor Compliance program (TPAC).

While the ATP Audit Program addresses aggressive tax planning by taxpayers who participated in such abusive insurance-related tax schemes, the TPAC program addresses non-compliance associated with promoters and advisors who promote or sell aggressive tax schemes. TPAC is accountable for identifying and combating aggressive tax schemes and holding promoters accountable through audit activities."

Navigating these statutory definitions requires an objective review to mitigate potential risks before an audit occurs.

Addendum: A Final Point on Property Characterization

It is useful to briefly test alternative characterizations of the relevant "property" under subsection 237.1(1) to confirm that shifting the framework does not bypass the statutory prescribed-benefit analysis.

- **1. The Investment as Property:** If the illustration represents that the borrowed funds were invested and the resulting interest is deductible, the income-producing investment is independently identifiable as the testable "interest in property" under Regulation 3100(1) to which the represented deduction relates.
- **2. The Policy as Property:** Alternatively, a promoter may argue that the life insurance policy itself is the relevant property. That characterization does not avoid the prescribed-benefit analysis – it simply requires establishing the link by a different route: the limited-recourse financing must be shown to be a prescribed benefit in respect of the purchaser's interest in the policy, typically by demonstrating that the policy and the financing were marketed and executed as a single, inseparable arrangement (see *Hexalog Ltée c. La Reine*). Once that link is established, the same arithmetic follows – the prescribed benefit reduces net cost to zero. Critically, if the promoter instead argues the deduction is not in respect of the policy at all, that position necessarily identifies the investment as the property to which the deduction relates, returning the inquiry directly to Scenario 1.

- 3. The Integrated Arrangement:** Finally, a promoter may attempt to inflate the tax-shelter cost denominator by characterizing the arrangement as a single integrated package – merging the cash-paid policy with the financed investment into one "composite property" – or by adding the loan's covenanted future interest onto the acquisition cost. Neither tactic withstands scrutiny. The Quebec Court of Appeal's reasoning in *Seica v. Agence du revenu du Québec* (2021 QCCA 1401) directly undercuts both. First, the Court held that the tax-shelter mathematical test applies on a property-by-property basis: two distinct interests acquired together through a single integrated, financed transaction remain separate properties for purposes of the test rather than merging into one composite asset. There is no principled basis to force an unleveraged policy and a leveraged investment into a single blended property where they otherwise retain independent character. Second, the Court held that "cost" under the mathematical test is not increased by interest covenanted to be paid under a promissory note – foreclosing any argument that total future loan interest should be capitalized into the acquisition cost. This result is reinforced by consistency: to claim the related interest deduction in the first place, the promoter must trace the borrowed funds to the income-producing investment, since interest on funds borrowed merely to acquire a personal life insurance policy is not independently deductible under paragraph 20(1)(c). Having isolated the investment to secure that deduction, the promoter cannot then treat the same investment as inseparable from the policy to inflate the denominator of an entirely different statutory test.

The essential point is consistency: the same borrowing cannot be relied upon to justify the interest deduction while simultaneously being disregarded when calculating the prescribed benefit against the property that generates that deduction. The precise statutory path depends on which property is characterized as relevant and how the "in respect of" relationship is established – but no available characterization avoids the prescribed-benefit inquiry altogether.

For a standard IFA illustration – where the loan matches the investment dollar-for-dollar and the full amount of interest is represented as deductible – the most direct analysis tests the investment itself (Scenario 1). Because the borrowing is a limited-recourse amount, it operates as a prescribed benefit in respect of that investment, producing a net cost of zero. Any represented deduction greater than zero then satisfies the numerical test in subsection 237.1(1).

Characteristics of an Immediate Financed Arrangement (IFA) Life Insurance Plan

Income Tax Rate: 50.17%

Loan Interest Rate: 5.00%

Deposits as Scheduled

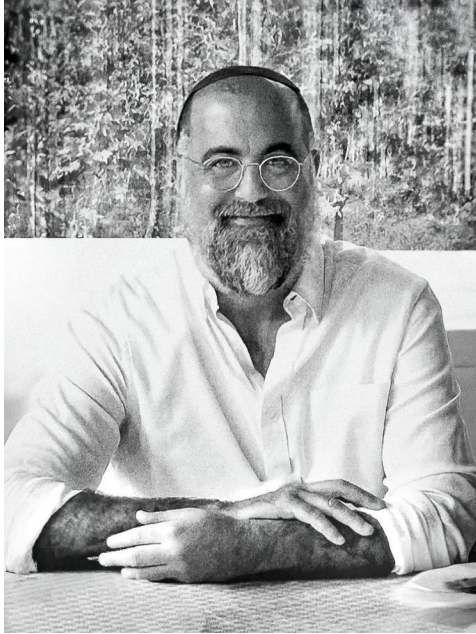
Dividend Scale Rate 5.35% (For Information Purposes Only)

Policy Information					Loan Details			Annual Deductions				Benefits
		#1	#2	#3	#4	#5	#6	#8	#9	#10	#11	#12
		Deposit	Cash Value	Death Benefit	Annual Loan Amount	Cumulative Loan Amount	Loan Security Collateral (#5 - #2)	Tax Deductible Interest	Tax Deductible Premium	Total Annual Tax Deductions (#8 + #9)	Total Annual Tax Savings (#10xTx%)	Net Death Benefit (#3 - #5)
1	60	\$100,000	\$61,091	\$1,446,039	\$100,000	\$100,000	\$38,909	\$5,000	\$175	\$5,175	\$2,596	1,346,039
2	61	100,000	127,089	1,586,368	100,000	200,000	72,911	10,000	486	10,486	5,261	1,386,368
3	62	100,000	197,740	1,728,112	100,000	300,000	102,260	15,000	896	15,896	7,975	1,428,112
4	63	100,000	272,084	1,868,904	100,000	400,000	127,916	20,000	1,417	21,417	10,745	1,468,904
5	64	100,000	349,913	2,008,261	100,000	500,000	150,087	25,000	2,060	27,060	13,576	1,508,261
6	65	100,000	447,235	2,146,651	100,000	600,000	152,765	30,000	2,845	32,845	16,478	1,546,651
7	66	100,000	554,921	2,284,685	100,000	700,000	145,079	35,000	3,790	38,790	19,461	1,584,685
8	67	100,000	673,270	2,422,740	100,000	800,000	126,730	40,000	4,915	44,915	22,534	1,622,740
9	68	100,000	802,556	2,561,174	100,000	900,000	97,444	45,000	6,243	51,243	25,709	1,661,174
10	69	100,000	943,038	2,700,334	100,000	1,000,000	56,962	50,000	7,789	57,789	28,993	1,700,334
11	70	0	995,100	2,666,002	0	1,000,000	4,900	50,000	8,874	58,874	29,537	1,666,002
12	71	0	1,054,681	2,634,855	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	10,053	60,053	30,128	1,634,855
13	72	0	1,121,971	2,606,979	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	11,348	61,348	30,778	1,606,979
14	73	0	1,197,165	2,582,453	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	12,739	62,739	31,476	1,582,453
15	74	0	1,280,453	2,561,357	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	14,229	64,229	32,224	1,561,357
16	75	0	1,323,698	2,543,051	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	15,829	65,829	33,027	1,543,051
17	76	0	1,368,098	2,526,713	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,133	66,133	33,179	1,526,713
18	77	0	1,414,037	2,512,257	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,226	66,226	33,225	1,512,257
19	78	0	1,461,654	2,499,626	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,308	66,308	33,266	1,499,626
20	79	0	1,511,107	2,488,774	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,379	66,379	33,302	1,488,774
21	80	0	1,562,582	2,479,661	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,439	66,439	33,332	1,479,661
22	81	0	1,616,301	2,472,255	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,488	66,488	33,357	1,472,255
23	82	0	1,672,174	2,466,528	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,526	66,526	33,376	1,466,528
24	83	0	1,729,676	2,462,467	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,554	66,554	33,390	1,462,467
25	84	0	1,788,435	2,460,038	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,570	66,570	33,398	1,460,038
26	85	0	1,848,331	2,459,189	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,576	66,576	33,401	1,459,189
27	86	0	1,909,255	2,459,866	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,571	66,571	33,399	1,459,866
28	87	0	1,971,085	2,462,024	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,557	66,557	33,391	1,462,024
29	88	0	2,033,645	2,465,619	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,532	66,532	33,379	1,465,619
30	89	0	2,096,731	2,470,612	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,499	66,499	33,363	1,470,612
31	90	0	2,159,535	2,476,217	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	16,462	66,462	33,344	1,476,217
32	91	0	2,229,555	2,530,229	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,530,229
33	92	0	2,298,778	2,584,179	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,584,179
34	93	0	2,368,072	2,638,095	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,638,095
35	94	0	2,438,237	2,691,999	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,691,999
36	95	0	2,509,972	2,745,912	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,745,912
37	96	0	2,584,750	2,799,844	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,799,844
38	97	0	2,665,320	2,853,789	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,853,789
39	98	0	2,756,593	2,907,715	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,907,715
40	99	0	2,867,532	2,961,547	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	1,961,547
41	100	0	3,015,145	3,015,145	0	1,000,000	0	50,000	0	50,000	25,085	2,015,145

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